

Session 5: Color-Evasive Practices

This week, participants will be asked to reflect on whether they have engaged or witnessed color-evasive rhetoric or practices in academic spaces, and how this knowledge, in combination with the knowledge of racialized experiences, has shaped how they will mentor students.

Things for facilitators to be prepared for:

Facilitators should be prepared for participants to experience discomfort as they examine color-evasive beliefs. Facilitators should be ready to redirect conversations to help participants connect broader systemic inequities to everyday mentoring behavior.

Participant Pre-Work:

- **Objective:** Provide participants with a general understanding of color-evasive practices and how they harm people of color.
 - **Activities:**
 - **TED Talk:** [Color Blind or Color Brave?](#) by Mellody Hobson
 - **Note:** Since 2014, the ableist term “color blind” has been replaced by “color evasive.”
 - **Video:** [Color Evasiveness](#) by Angela Davis
 - **Reflection:** Consider the following statements. How does each statement lack a racial awareness lens? What are the potential effects of these statements on students of color? For each statement, what situation is more likely to be true?
 - **Statement A:** "I think if students of color just felt more confident and asked for help, they would be fine."
 - **Statement B:** "In some communities, families just don't have the same love of science."
 - **Statement C:** "It's not racial, it's about students who are from low-income schools that are underprepared."
 - **Submission:** Be ready to share your questions and reflections during the synchronous session.
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Synchronous Session:

- **Materials needed:**
 - [Color Evasive Discussion Scenarios](#)
 - [Facilitator answers to guided questions](#)
 - [Color Evasiveness and Systemic Racism Statements](#)
 - [Session 5 Survey](#)
 - [Survey results from previous sessions](#)

- Access to Zoom and familiarity with creating break-out rooms
- **Learning Objectives:**
 - **Objective 1:** Be able to identify, challenge, and dismantle color-evasive behaviors, languages, and practices.
 - **Objective 2:** Articulate the subtle but lasting effects color-evasive language can have on mentees.
- **Reviewing Survey Results:**
 - Before each session, all facilitators should plan to [review the survey results from the previous session](#). This is so they are able to incorporate any participant feedback into their session and make any adjustments.
- **Pework for Facilitator 2:**
 - Set all observers/facilitators as hosts (unless they want to be assigned to breakout rooms)
 - Set up screen with 5-minute Google timer, ready to share
 - Set up first breakout room: 2 participants per breakout room, 8 minutes auto-recall
 - **Facilitator 2** starts recording, **Facilitator 3** backs up at starting/stopping recording for breakouts
 - **Facilitator 3** starts recording.
- Note for all facilitators: make sure to rename yourself as “Facilitator” in the Zoom name.

Live Session Agenda:

- **Welcome and Warm-up Activity: 00:00 - 00:05 (5 min)**
 - **Activity Type:** Group Check-In
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 2** posts to chat “As you enter, type in the chat. What is a plant that reminds you of home?”
- **Intro to Color Evasiveness: 00:05 - 00:10 (5 min)**
 - **Activity Type:** Introduction
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 2** pastes into chat as **Facilitator 1** introduces participants to the concept of color-evasiveness, focusing on:
 - Definition: Color evasiveness is the denial of racial differences by emphasizing sameness. This can be seen in statements such as “I don’t see color” or “It doesn’t matter if you’re Black, white, yellow, or purple.”
 - Root Cause: Color-evasiveness occurs as a result of discomfort around the topic of race, typically because acknowledging race would force the person to confront bias, systemic inequities, and even their own sense of self. Color evasiveness is a protective mechanism to allay cognitive dissonance or identity crisis.

- Effect: When we avoid talking about or acknowledging race and racism, we willfully ignore the experiences of people of color, rendering them invisible or even untrue.
- **Homework Reflection: 00:10 - 00:25 (15 minutes)**
 - **Activity type**: Large Group Discussion
 - **Description**: **Facilitator 1** will guide participants through a review of their homework reflections, highlighting key insights and discussing the following:
 - **Facilitator 2** pastes into chat one at a time (as **Facilitator 1** reads aloud):
 - How does each statement lack a racial awareness lens? What are the potential effects of these statements on students of color? For each statement, what situation is more likely to be true?
 - Statement A: "I think if students of color just felt more confident and asked for help, they would be fine."
 - Statement B: "In some communities, families just don't have the same love of science."
 - Statement C: "It's not racial, it's about students who are from low-income schools that are underprepared."
- **BREAK: 00:25 - 00:30 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 2** shares their screen with the timer countdown and takes [attendance](#)
 - **Facilitator 3**: Stop recording during break, restarts recording after break
- **Color-Evasiveness in Action: 00:30 - 00:40 (10 min)**
 - **Activity type**: Pair Breakouts
 - **Description**: **Facilitator 1** introduces three scenarios for pairs to discuss in breakout sessions. **Facilitator 2** will set up breakout rooms titled by scenario (i.e. "Scenario 2" instead of "Breakout Room 5"), ensuring an even distribution.
 - **Facilitator 2** will paste a link to the [Color Evasive Discussion Scenarios](#) with the three scenarios and questions in the chat
 - What would be a color-evasive response to this situation?
 - What would be a color-brave response to this situation?
 - How does this situation negatively affect people of color?
 - **Facilitator 3** stops recording during the breakouts
 - **Facilitator 2** broadcasts a 3-minute warning before breakouts end
- **Color Evasiveness Large Group Discussion: 00:40 - 00:55 (15 min)**
 - **Facilitator 3** restarts recording
 - **Description**: **Facilitator 2** pastes the questions into the chat. **Facilitator 1** guides participants through a discussion of their scenarios and their answers to the questions.
 - **Guiding Questions**:
 - What would be a color-evasive response to this

- situation?
 - What would be a color-brave response to this situation?
 - How does this situation negatively affect people of color?
- **BREAK: 00:55 - 01:00 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 2** shares their screen with the timer countdown
 - **Facilitator 3: Stop recording during break, start recording after break**
- **Color Evasiveness and Systemic Racism: 01:00 - 01:25 (25 min)**
 - **Activity type:** Large Group Share Discussion
 - **Description:** **Facilitator 1** reads discussion questions out loud, asks participants to expand on them, and guides them through a discussion.
 - **Facilitator 2** pastes the discussion questions in the Zoom chat one by one (as they're being discussed) and keeps track of the discussion, ensuring that there's time for all three guiding questions.
 - How does color-evasive ideology allow scientists to sidestep responsibility in addressing racial inequality in their disciplines? (b) In what ways could good intentions still result in bad consequences?
 - What's the difference between explaining underrepresentation as a result of 'individual choice' versus 'systemic racism'? (b) How do these two views shape the types of mentoring or institutional changes one would recommend?
 - Where do you identify potential for learning or change in your own practice?
 - Note: Facilitators may refer to [this section](#) for potential answers to guiding questions.
- **Wrap-Up: 01:25 - 01:30 (5 min)**
 - **Facilitator 1** summarizes key points from the session and opens the floor for final questions and comments.
 - **Facilitator 2** shares the link to the [Session 5 Survey](#) in the chat and asks participants to complete it as soon as they can.
 - **Facilitator 1** ends the session by reminding participants of the pre-work for session 5, thanks them for joining, and ends the session.
 - **Facilitator 3 stops the recording.**

Facilitator Notes:

The Facilitators should spend time writing down everything they observed during the session (what worked, what didn't, and what improvements need to be made). They can also include advice for the next facilitator to watch out for. Facilitators may use the following guiding questions:

- How did the session go?
- Was there active participation in discussions?
- Do you feel like the learning objectives were met?
- Are there topics that need to be revisited in the next session?

- Were participants fully engaged when discussing their own mentoring experiences or goals?
 - Were there times of vulnerability, disagreement, or hesitation? How were they managed?
 - Did the conversation about group norms seem genuine and open? Were any important issues addressed?
 - Are there any organizational improvements (tech, timing, breakout structure) to be addressed before the next session?
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Facilitator answers to the Guided Questions for Section 7: Color-Evasiveness and Systemic Racism.

1 - (a) How does color-[evasive] ideology allow faculty to sidestep responsibility in addressing racial inequality in their disciplines?

- Color-[evasive] ideology allows instructors to explain inequality away without reference to racism. By identifying causes in terms of individual traits or family backgrounds, they avoid examining themselves or institutional procedures that lead to exclusion. This protects their "racial innocence" and prevents action.

(b) In what ways could good intentions still result in bad consequences?

- Good intentions, like a desire to be "fair" by being equal with every student, can still have negative consequences. For example, sidestepping attention to race can involve missing the chance to assist students who are under threat of stereotype or microaggressions. Staff may be accidentally reinforcing systems that punish students of color by resisting the need to change practice.

2 - (a) What's the difference between explaining underrepresentation as a result of 'individual choice' versus 'systemic racism'?

- Attributing underrepresentation to individual choice means that students alone are accountable for their success or failure (e.g., a lack of interest, confidence, or motivation).
- By contrast, systemic racism sees inequality as stemming from broader structures, biased admissions, toxic climates, or curriculum that demotes non-white achievement.

(b) How do these two views shape the types of mentoring or institutional changes one would recommend?

- The individual choice model leads to mentoring that is concerned with "fixing" the student, conferring confidence, promoting independence.
- The systemic racism frame calls for institutional change: liberalizing instruction, addressing bias in the lab, altering admissions or promotion policies. Mentorship is employed as a tool of knocking down barriers, not just advising people.

(c) Where do you identify potential for learning or change in your own practice?

- There's always room for growth. I can go back to how I talk about "merit," whose lives I recognize, and how I create space for students to negotiate belonging and identity. I can attempt to listen for when "support" looks different in each setting of culture and adapt my mentoring accordingly.